

Why I Write

Martin Iver Jacobsen | August, 2026

Of course I stole the title of this essay from George Orwell. And of course I stole that sentence from Joan Didion. The reason I stole them is that these writers already seem to have said everything I have to say on the subject. I have no new reasons for writing and I claim no new purpose for it. I have only the old ones, and insofar as they differ from theirs, it is only because they are mine.

I didn't write as a child. This is not to say that I never put words on paper. Like every schoolchild, I wrote what I was told to write: essays, stories, lab reports, and analyses of whatever poem was being forced down my reluctant throat at the time. The pages I handed in contained letters and words and sentences, and they were not all bad, but I don't think of any of this as writing. There was nothing of me in it. The pages contained ink, but no blood.

Around the age of nineteen, I went to university to study economics and began writing summaries of the courses I took. This was still not writing in the sense I mean it here, but it was perhaps a little closer. The first summary I wrote was in a mandatory philosophy course that almost every student dreaded. I actually liked it, but I found the textbook rather dull and not always very clear, and decided that if I was going to read it at all, once would have to be enough. So I wrote a summary of it which I could study later and shared it with a few classmates. They, it turned out, shared it with others, and before long my little compendium had become more or less the curriculum.

In the process of writing it, I discovered that writing forced me to think more carefully than reading alone ever had. To put an argument down in my own words, to decide what mattered and what did not, was a concentrated form of thought, and I found that I understood the material better for having written it down. There was also the simpler satisfaction of having made something that other people found useful. But I should not pretend that this satisfaction was entirely altruistic. I liked being talked about. And I liked being thought clever.

Sometime during my graduate years, I discovered another pleasure in writing. It was no longer enough merely to have said something clearly; I began to care whether I had said it well. I seemed to have a thing for economists named Robert at the time, for I remember reading Robert Heilbroner's *The Worldly Philosophers*, Robert Frank's *Passions Within Reason*, and Robert Skidelsky's *The Return of the Master*, and being struck by how clear their prose was without being dull, and how elegant it was without feeling forced. The papers I wrote at the time must, I suppose, have reflected the styles of these and other writers I admired, but so far as I remember I always found pleasure, if not in writing, then in having written something that seemed to flow almost effortlessly from one paragraph to the next. Looking back, however, I was still insecure enough to insert literary references and Latin phrases wherever an opportunity presented itself, usually for no better reason than that I hoped somebody would be impressed.

For the most part, prose became a way of finding out what I thought about the world. There was a question I wanted to find an answer to, and by writing about it I could discover what I thought the answer was. But every now and then a phrase or an image would come to me, and I would follow it much like a child who has spotted a butterfly and wanders after it simply to see where it goes. These wanderings usually became short poems, and over the years I have written perhaps twenty or thirty of them. One came from a small birch tree I used to pass on my walks through a valley where the wind had bent nearly every other tree towards the ground. Year after year I expected winter to do the same to this one, but each spring it was still there, and after a while it seemed to me an obvious image of a person I knew. It took me a day to write that poem. A day of adventure. It began with a thought, which took on a direction, and found its own way to a conclusion I didn't foresee. And for me that's the whole delight.

These last few years I have mostly written about the things that interest me: music, movies, mathematics; things beginning with M, apparently. Essays, and the occasional small textbook. None of it was assigned, and none of it was for anyone in particular. I write about these things because they are important to me, because I want to understand them, and I want to find out what I have to say about them. But I don't think I would do the writing if there were not also some pleasure in finding the right words and their right arrangement. Pleasure in the impact of a good paragraph and in seeing the figure good prose makes. I do not know the secret behind making those shapes any more than I know how Michelangelo could see David in that block of marble. I will only say that I have tried to write more concretely, and with more restraint. None of it has satisfied me, and I suspect none of it will. But I know, more clearly than I used to, what I

want the writing to be.

Looking back through the last two pages, I see that it may appear that I think of myself as a writer. I do not. I do not place myself among the Orwells and Didions of this world and I do not think of writing as an identity or vocation. I write because every now and then an idea takes hold of me and refuses to leave. An unwritten idea is a parasite in the mind. It is a persistent discomfort, like a speck of dirt trapped under the eyelid, and I have found no reliable way of getting rid of it except by writing. I have also discovered, rather slowly, that the only things I have written with which I have been genuinely content are those that grew out of my own experiences. I remember reading Aldous Huxley's *The Rest Is Silence* and Nick Cave's *The Secret Life of the Love Song* and wanting to write the same things. So I tried. The trouble was that Huxley and Cave had already written them, and they had done so as Huxley and Cave. When I tried, the result was pretentious, sterile, and, for the most part, humbug. Whatever merits those thoughts had in their hands, they lost them when I dressed them up as mine. To put pen to paper is, in some sense, to bleed, and I have learned that the only blood I can bleed is my own.